

By Amitabh Srivastava

When 14-year-old Pinki Khakha giggles while talking to strangers, she can easily be mistaken for yet another teenager full of life. The smile, however, lasts only for a minute as dark memories begin to haunt her. On the night of January 2, 2010, when the world was stepping into a new year, Pinki's life changed for ever. A few men barged into her house at Saudag village, 20 km from Ranchi district headquarters and hacked her parents Soma Khakha, Jirgi and elder sister Fulmani to death. Reason? They were accused of practising witchcraft. Pinki, who had locked herself in a room, survived, only to be left with indelible scars of the gruesome event. The police arrested three

Medieval FEVER

The witch-hunt never ends in Jharkhand as women, sometimes with their families, are meted out harsh punishment by upholders of a savage justice

Phatu Devi, 45

Seraikela-Kharsawan district, Jharkhand

A village committee convicted Phatu Devi (right) for killing an 11-month-old boy through black magic. She had gone to her son-in-law's house to see her daughter. A day later, her son-in-law's nephew died. The infant's body was exhumed and placed in Phatu's lap. She was locked in a room and ordered to bring the kid back to life. When she failed, it was decided that she'd be killed. Chhutni Mahtain (left) who works for the NGO FLAC informed the police, who came to Phatu's rescue.



ARVIND KR SHARMA

Sanjay, 13, and Nitish, 10

Kamalpur village, Bihar

Sanjay and Nitish lost their family to a gruesome act of witch-hunting. Shivcharan Mehta, his wife Kari Devi and daughter-in-law Siya Devi had been subjected to attacks for a year as the villagers accused them of casting a spell on one of the locals who died. One day, the trio had their hair chopped before they were forced to eat human waste. They consumed poison the same night. Sanjay and Nitish now stay with their step-mother Sony Devi (in the picture).

relatives—Risha, Nago and Mangra Khakha—for the crime. Apparently, the trio had harassed Soma earlier, accusing him of practising black magic. They had also blamed Pinki's family when Risha's 12-year-old daughter Suman died of a mysterious disease a few months ago. They killed the three to avenge the death. The police, however, has reasons to suspect a property angle in the case.

This is but one among the hundreds of cases of witch killings in Jharkhand,

a state that is fast gaining notoriety for being a haven for crimes against women. The National Crime Records Bureau (NCRB) records state that Jharkhand has witnessed deaths of 249 persons (mostly women) between 2001 and 2008 for "practising witchcraft". Worse still, the state alone has accounted for nearly 30 per cent of the witchcraft killings in the country in both 2007 and 2008. The Jharkhand Criminal Investigation Department figures maintain that as many as 1,200

witches managed to survive torture and attacks between 2001 and 2009. The figures suggest that the last two years have been worse in terms of rising attacks—or the best for survivors when as many as 321 witches managed to escape death. Even by government figures, which are largely considered conservative since not all cases are reported, every second day a woman in Jharkhand is branded a witch and made to suffer. The frequency of such assaults and the dismal conviction rate,

